ONCE THE SOVIET SHIPS ENTERED THE ATLANTIC AND BEGAN to approach Cuba, the KGB officers found a new and more important subject of surveillance and reporting—American airplanes overflying the Soviet vessels. The senior KGB officers in Moscow to whom the reports were ultimately addressed found that the later a ship approached Cuba, the greater the number of overflights to which it was subjected.

Major Morozov reported that the *Metallurg Bardin* was overflown by a US Navy plane only once on its way to Cuba, on August 18. But on the way back, on August 31, another US airplane overflew the ship five times in the course of twenty minutes. Something had changed in the American attitude toward the Soviet ships. Major Zozulia all but lost count of the overflights of *Ilia Mechnikov* as it approached Cuban waters on August 28. "The overflights were conducted at a very low level and in different directions," wrote Zozulia. "One plane would fly off, only to be replaced by another after a short time. Every plane carried out two or three overflights of the ship." The Americans were clearly getting more worried about the Soviet ships as August drew to a close.[21]

The continuing American overflights meant one thing: the deal that Nikita Khrushchev had been trying to strike with John Kennedy the previous month was not materializing. In July, with ships en route to Cuba, Khrushchev had decided to enlist the help of President Kennedy himself to get the U-2 and other reconnaissance planes off their back as they transported Soviet missiles to Cuba. John Kennedy seemed open to Khrushchev's idea but wanted something in return—that the Berlin issue be put "on ice." Khrushchev played for time, instructing his secret representative in Washington, Colonel Georgii Bolshakov, to ask Kennedy what putting on ice really meant. It was a mistake. The deal never went into effect.[22]